THE EASE OF LIVING

The centrally-sponsored scheme on micro-irrigation was first launched in January 2006 but it was only in April 2015—when it was subsumed under the Pradhan Mantri Krishi Sinchai Yojana (PMKSY) and states were given targets—that it actually started picking up. In July 2015, it was rechristened PMKSY: Per Drop More Crop (PDMC), by the department of agriculture and farmers' welfare.

As part of the scheme, the government underwrites between 45 per cent and 55 per cent of the initial cost of installing micro-irrigation systems such as drips and sprinklers on farms, automatically reducing water usage by 50 per cent. Add state government incentives and the subsidy goes up to 70 per cent. The average cost of setting up a micro irrigation system is around Rs 50,000 per acre.

Micro-irrigation systems have reduced water usage by 50 per cent. Farmers, too, don't have to be at the mercy of weather conditions

To address the primary concern of water availability at source, PDMC also helps in creating micro-level water storage by harnessing rainwater, efficient water conveyance, and topping up of input cost for water lifting devices. At the village level, the government underwrites up to 60 per cent of the expense of creating alternative micro-level local water storages, typically a village pond.

The biggest gain from the PDMC is the reduced dependence of the farmer on weather conditions—and hence the uncertainty associated with farming—leading to better planning, more diversity of crops, better soil health, higher acreage and, in the end, higher profitability. The drip irrigation system also comes in useful for administering fertiliser. This has reduced labour costs, one of the highest components in farming, to less than half. ■



HOW IT TRANSFORMED MY LIFE

"Now we grow crops at a quarter of the cost"

LALIT PATEL, 58
Navanagar village, Sabarkantha, Gujarat

Till 15 years back, Lalit Patel would harvest just one crop of cotton a year. Prudent water management, and the state's Per Drop More Crop (PDMC) scheme have meant he can now harvest up to three diverse crops. His income has gone up from Rs 25,000 per hectare a season to Rs 1.25 lakh per hectare.

The Gujarat government first introduced the micro-irrigation scheme in 2005 and Patel was among the first farmers to sign up and have drip irrigation and sprinkler systems installed on his 15-acre farm. By 2010, every farm in the village of 100-odd households, with some 460 hectares between them, had switched to the micro-irrigation systems. "Now, after harvesting the cotton crop in October-November, we grow musk melon for the three months of winter. After that, we switch to either vegetables like cauliflower, tomato, brinjal, potato, or go for peanuts, saunf (fennel) or castor," he says.

Patel's fortunes have taken a turn for the better not only because he can harvest more, but also because his expenses per acre have reduced to a fourth. "The water table was depleting so rapidly that it was available only after 550 feet. We spent up to Rs 17,000 per month on electricity. Now, we use a 5 HP motor for sprinkler and drip irrigation systems, and the cost is just Rs 2,000 per month," says Patel.

The benefits stretch much beyond that now. Around 300 farmers in Navanagar have formed a water cooperative, another for seed and fertiliser as well as a farmer producer organisation (FPO) through which they are directly in touch with commodity traders, which helps them evade the middlemen and maximise profit. ■